10.2 Spices and Condiments

"Aroma attracts everyone"

History:

Spices were used extensively throughout the world for several thousands of years. Records of use of garlic and onion dates back 2500 years.

Majority of the spices are native to Mediterranean region, India and South East Asian countries. Spices, especially pepper triggered the search for sea route to India and paved way for the exploratory voyages by Spanish and Portuguese.

Spices are accessory foods mainly used for flavouring during food preparation to improve their palatability. Spices are aromatic plant products and are characterized by sweet or bitter taste. Spices are added in minimal quantities during the cooking process. For example black pepper.

Condiments, on the other hand, are flavouring substances having a sharp taste and are usually added to food after cooking. For example, curry leaves.

The following spices and condiment are discussed in detail.

Spices

Cardamom

Botanical name : *Elettaria cardamomum*

Family : Zingiberaceae

Origin and Area of cultivation: It is indigenous to Southern India and Sri Lanka. Cardamom is called as **"Queen of Spices"**. In India it is one of the main cash crops cultivated in the Western Ghats, and North Eastern India

Uses

The seeds have a pleasing aroma and a characteristic warm, slightly pungent taste. It is used for flavouring confectionaries, bakery products and beverages. The seeds are used in the preparation of curry powder, pickles and cakes. Medicinally, it is employed as a stimulant and carminative. It is also chewed as a mouth freshener.

Black Pepper

Botanical name : *Piper nigrum*

Family : Piperaceae

Origin and Area of cultivation: It is indigenous to Western Ghats of India. Pepper is one of the most important Indian spices referred to as the **"King of Spices"** and also termed as **"Black Gold of India"**. Kerala, Karnataka and Tamil Nadu are the top producers in India.

The characteristic pungency of the pepper is due to the presence of alkaloid Piperine. There are two types of pepper available in the market namely black and white pepper.

Uses

It is used for flavouring in the preparation of sauces, soups, curry powder and pickles. It is used in medicine as an aromatic stimulant for enhancing salivary and gastric secretions and also as a stomachic. Pepper also enhances the bio-absorption of medicines.

Turmeric

Botanical name : *Curcuma longa*

Family : Zingiberaceae

Origin and Area of cultivation: It is indigenous to Southern Asia India is the largest producer, consumer and exporter of



Figure 10.12: Spices

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